

DIVERSE PERSPECTIVES ON JUSTICE

UPSC PRELIMS + GS MAINS | PRIMARY HOME: GS-II CONCEPTUAL FOUNDATIONS

Continuous core-first rail | Advanced enrichment stays subordinate to the GS core

1

ORIGIN AND DATED RAIL

1690	John Locke's Second Treatise of Government
1724-1804	Immanuel Kant
1748-1832	Jeremy Bentham
1756-1836	William Godwin
1759-97	When Mary WoUstonecraft
1792	Vindication of the Rights of Woman
1793	In his Enquiry Concerning Political Justice
1806-73	John Stuart Mill
1809-82	Charles Darwin
1814-76	Mikhail Bakunin
1828-1910	Leo Tolstoy
1842-1921	Then Peter Kropotkin
1847-1922	George Sorel
1848	Marx and Engels in their Communist Manifesto
1848-1923	Vilfredo Pareto
1858-1941	Gaetano Mosca
1859	Contribution to the Critique of Political Economy
1861-79	Marx's Capital
1869-1948	Mahatma Gandhi
1869	The Subjection of Women
1875	Again, in his Critique of the Gotha Programme
1876-1936	Robert Michels

MECHANISM

Chronology fixes what each named work actually changed, so the argument cannot slide into a vague rise-and-fall story.

TRAP / LIMIT

Rawls wants identical outcomes for all -> Rawls permits inequality after liberty and fair opportunity, provided it benefits the least advantaged. (PDF p.448)

ANSWER LINE

Gauba opens the chapter by treating justice as a field of many rival perspectives rather than one settled formula. (PDF p.446)

2

CORE DEFINITIONS THE EXAMINER EXPECTS VERBATIM

Term	Exam-ready meaning
Primary goods	Rawls's distributive object: rights, liberties, powers, opportunities, income, wealth and the social bases of self-respect. (PDF p.447)
Original position	Rawls's hypothetical starting point where rational persons choose principles of justice without knowing their actual social place. (PDF p.447)
Veil of ignorance	The condition in which parties lack knowledge of their particular wants, talents, class position and other discriminatory markers. (PDF p.447)

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Veil of ignorance	The condition in which parties lack knowledge of their particular wants, talents, class position and other discriminatory markers. (PDF p.447)
Equal basic liberties	Rawls's first principle: each person has an equal claim to the most extensive compatible liberty. (PDF p.448)
Fair equality of opportunity	Rawls's second-stage rule that offices and positions should be open on genuinely fair terms, not merely formal legal equality. (PDF p.448)
Difference principle	Rawls's rule that inequality is just only if it brings the greatest benefit to the least advantaged. (PDF p.448)
Entitlement theory	Nozick's view that holdings are just if they arise from just acquisition, voluntary transfer and, where needed, rectification. (PDF pp.450-452)
Subaltern	Groups kept in subordinate, exploited or marginalized positions by structural inequalities and hegemonic domination. (PDF pp.467-469)
Situated / embedded self	Communitarian idea that persons discover themselves within social roles, traditions and shared ends, not in abstraction from them. (PDF pp.469-472)

MECHANISM

Definition control is the cheapest mark in this topic: the stem is usually built from one of these exact terms.

TRAP / LIMIT

The difference principle alone is enough to justify an inequality -> Equal basic liberties and fair equality of opportunity have lexical priority

ANSWER LINE

Gauba begins with the liberal perspective and presents Rawls as the major attempt to reconcile liberty with equality and fraternity within a broader liberal frame. (PDF p.446)

3

CHAPTER SPINE, STEP BY STEP

- Gauba begins with the liberal perspective and presents Rawls as the major attempt to reconcile liberty with equality and fraternity within a broader liberal frame. (PDF p.446)
- Rawls rejects utilitarian sacrifice of some for aggregate happiness and instead asks what principles free and rational agents would choose under fairness conditions. (PDF pp.447-448)
- Gauba then shifts to the libertarian perspective, where Nozick opposes redistributive welfare and treats justice historically through titles and transfers, not patterned end-states. (PDF pp.450-452)
- The Marxist discussion rejects repair of capitalism through mere fairer shares and locates injustice in exploitation, surplus value and private ownership of major means of production. (PDF pp.452-459)
- Democratic socialism softens the revolutionary route, combines socialism with democratic freedoms, and seeks welfare plus civil liberties through constitutional politics. (PDF pp.459-461)
- Anarchism radicalizes suspicion of coercive authority by arguing that justice needs the shrinking or abolition of state power and domination. (PDF pp.461-464)
- Feminist justice makes gender hierarchy a central political problem and presses for rights, opportunities, representation and compensatory measures. (PDF pp.464-468)
- Subaltern justice reframes distribution around structurally subordinated groups whose labour and contribution are undervalued under elite hegemony. (PDF pp.467-469)
- Communitarian justice criticizes liberal neutrality and insists that right cannot be understood apart from shared conceptions of the good and community life. (PDF pp.469-473)

MECHANISM

The spine is the order in which the source itself develops the argument; reproducing it keeps the answer sequenced rather than listed.

TRAP / LIMIT

Nozick is anti-justice -> Nozick proposes a full theory of justice, but one centred on entitlement rather than redistribution. (PDF pp.451-452)

ANSWER LINE

Rawlsian justice is not flat equality; liberty comes first, opportunity next, and only then may inequalities be permitted if they help the least advantaged. (PDF p.448)

4

THINKERS, NAMED WORKS AND THE PROPOSITIONS THEY FIX

John Rawls

Justice as fairness through two lexically ordered principles: equal basic liberties; then fair opportunity plus the difference principle, chosen in the original position. Gauba explains the second principle's two parts as separate steps (PDF pp.447-450)

Marx and Engels

Capitalist injustice lies in exploitation of labour, surplus value and private ownership of major means of production; communist society aims to end class domination. (PDF pp.452-459)

Godwin / Proudhon / Bakunin / Kropotkin / Tolstoy / Gandhi / Bookchin

Anarchist family members differ, but all distrust coercive authority and seek justice through decentralized, voluntary or morally regenerated association. (PDF pp.461-464)

Book-period gender indicators

Gauba uses development and empowerment indicators to show that gender justice includes health, education and power, not merely formal rights. (PDF pp.466-468)

Robert Nozick

Justice as entitlement grounded jointly in self-ownership, just initial acquisition, voluntary transfer and rectification under a minimal protective state (PDF pp.450-452)

Harold Laski / E.F.M. Durbin

Democratic socialism combines socialist justice with democratic method, civil liberties and public services. (PDF pp.459-461)

Mary Wollstonecraft / J.S. Mill

Early feminist demand for equal rights, education, property and political citizenship for women. (PDF pp.465-466)

Antonio Gramsci

Subaltern justice exposes hegemony, elite-centred history and exploitation masked as consent. (PDF pp.467-469)

Godwin / Proudhon / Bakunin / Kropotkin / Tolstoy / Gandhi / Bookchin Anarchist family members differ, but all distrust coercive authority and seek justice through decentralized, voluntary or morally regenerated association. (PDF pp.461-464)	Mary Wollstonecraft / J.S. Mill Early feminist demand for equal rights, education, property and political citizenship for women. (PDF pp.465-466)
Book-period gender indicators Gaubas uses development and empowerment indicators to show that gender justice includes health, education and power, not merely formal rights. (PDF pp.466-468)	Antonio Gramsci Subaltern justice exposes hegemony, elite-centred history and exploitation masked as consent. (PDF pp.467-469)
MacIntyre / Sandel / Taylor / Walzer Communitarian thinkers stress virtue, embeddedness, social context and sphere-specific meanings of goods against abstract liberal universalism. (PDF pp.470-473)	
MECHANISM A named proposition earns marks only when it is tied to the analytical use the question demands.	
TRAP / LIMIT Any voluntary market transfer is just for Nozick -> The transfer must rest on just title; acquisition, transfer and rectification form a connected historical test	
ANSWER LINE Thinker / stream - Position in this topic	

5

ILLUSTRATIONS ATTACHED TO THE CLAIMS THEY SUPPORT

Rawls's anti-utilitarian point is illustrated by the Rawls's anti-utilitarian point is illustrated by the possibility that aggregate happiness could rise even while a minority is enslaved; he rejects such trade-offs. (PDF p.447)	Nozick's Wilt Chamberlain example shows why voluntary Nozick's Wilt Chamberlain example shows why voluntary exchange may generate inequality without, in his view, making the outcome unjust. (PDF p.451)
Nozick's water-source example shows that initial acquisition Nozick's water-source example shows that initial acquisition is not unlimited; control over an indispensable natural resource cannot rightfully make others worse off. (PDF p.451)	Marxist surplus-value analysis illustrates injustice when Marxist surplus-value analysis illustrates injustice when labour creates more value than the worker receives back as wages. (PDF pp.453-455)
Feminist justice is illustrated through historically denied Feminist justice is illustrated through historically denied rights to women's education, property, vote and occupations, followed by claims for compensatory measures. (PDF pp.465-468)	Subaltern justice is illustrated through the contrast between Subaltern justice is illustrated through the contrast between elite theory, which naturalizes rule, and Gramsci's view that hegemony makes subordination look consensual. (PDF pp.468-469)
Walzer's example of keeping money from corrupting politics, Walzer's example of keeping money from corrupting politics, health and education illustrates communitarian "complex equality." (PDF p.473)	In answer writing, treat these as timeless conceptual In answer writing, treat these as timeless conceptual illustrations or clearly historical book-period examples, not present-day statistics

MECHANISM Examples are evidence only when the answer states what they prove and where they stop proving it.
TRAP / LIMIT Marxism has nothing to do with justice -> Gauba says that would be too strong, because Marx condemns exploitation and endorses superior distributive principles in a classless order. (PDF p.453)
ANSWER LINE Rawls's anti-utilitarian point is illustrated by the possibility that aggregate happiness could rise even while a minority is enslaved; he rejects such trade-offs. (PDF p.447)

6

COMPARISON MATRIX

Perspective	Distribution rule	State	Property	Equality	Community	Critique
Rawlsian liberal	Equal liberties first; the second principle then requires fair opportunity before inequalities can be tested by the difference principle (PDF p.448)	Active state may pursue distributive justice and regulate inequalities. (PDF pp.448-450)	Retains capitalism conditionally, but only in a more humane, regulated form. (PDF p.450)	Equal liberty plus justified inequality, not simple leveling. (PDF pp.448-449)	Gaubas "chain connection" is his explanatory presentation of social interdependence, not a substitute for Rawls's ordered principles	Criticized by collectivists, Marxists, libertarians and communitarians from different angles. (PDF pp.448-449)
Libertarian (Nozick)	Historical entitlement through just acquisition, voluntary transfer and rectification. All three matter (PDF pp.450-452)	Minimal protective state plus rectification, not patterned welfare redistribution. (PDF pp.451-452)	Strong private property and self-ownership are central to liberty, qualified by just title and the acquisition proviso	Equality of outcome is irrelevant only where holdings arose justly	Community does not automatically ground coercive redistribution; voluntary aid remains possible	Criticized for underestimating structural injustice and the indeterminacy of rectification
Marxist	Ultimately distribution by need in communist society; under capitalism, justice cannot be reduced to fair shares inside an exploitative system. (PDF pp.453, 458-459)	Socialist state is transitional, then expected to wither away with class abolition. (PDF pp.455-459)	Abolishes private ownership of major means of production while distinguishing personal property. (PDF pp.458-459)	Seeks abolition of exploitative class inequality. (PDF pp.453-459)	Envisions classless association where free development of each supports all. (PDF pp.458-459)	Criticized because new domination may reappear through political or bureaucratic power. (PDF p.459)
Democratic-socialist	Social justice through partial socialization, welfare, public services and democratic rights. (PDF pp.459-461)	Strong welfare-democratic state, but not dictatorship. (PDF pp.460-461)	Mixed regime: some essential sectors under state ownership, not wholesale abolition. (PDF p.459)	Combines socio-economic justice with civil liberties and personality development. (PDF pp.459-460)	Public opinion, work culture and democratic institutions are needed to sustain it. (PDF p.461)	Criticized as hard to fund and politically difficult to sustain without coercion or incentive loss. (PDF p.461)
Anarchist	Equitable sharing through voluntary cooperation, mutualism or communal association, not imposed hierarchy. (PDF pp.461-464)	State is coercive evil to be abolished or progressively diluted. (PDF pp.461-464)	Often hostile to property as domination, though strands differ. (PDF pp.462-464)	Equality means release from domination by state, hierarchy and exploitative ownership. (PDF pp.462-464)	Small associations, federations and mutual aid are preferred to centralized rule. (PDF pp.462-464)	Criticized as politically impracticable, overly optimistic about human nature, and weak on regulation. (PDF p.464)
Feminist	Justice requires equal rights plus corrective support against gendered disadvantage. (PDF pp.465-468)	State may need to secure education, representation, reservations and protective benefits. (PDF pp.466-468)	Challenges women's historic exclusion from property ownership and economic power. (PDF pp.465-468)	Equality includes effective status, empowerment, participation and share in power. (PDF pp.466-468)	Community arrangements are suspect when they naturalize patriarchal roles. (PDF pp.465-467)	Critiques social arrangements that turn biological difference into unwarranted subordination. (PDF pp.465-468)

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Subaltern	Justice means restoring equitable shares, rights, dignity and protection to structurally subordinated groups. (PDF pp.467-469)	State and history-writing must stop privileging elites and must protect marginalized groups. (PDF pp.468-469)	Property/class matters, but subordination extends beyond ownership into caste, culture, gender and hegemony. (PDF pp.467-469)	Equality means ending undeserved subordination and rewarding contribution fairly. (PDF pp.468-469)	Community is divided by ruling-class hegemony unless subaltern agency can organize and speak. (PDF pp.467-469)	Critiques elite theory for naturalizing rule and minimizing subordinate agency. (PDF pp.468-469)
Communitarian	Distribution should reflect community meanings, virtue and sphere-specific reasons, not one abstract universal metric. (PDF pp.469-473)	State is not neutral umpire alone; it may legitimately sustain common goods and proper boundaries between spheres. (PDF pp.470-473)	Property is not the sole key to social worth; money must not dominate every sphere. (PDF pp.472-473)	Rejects simple equality; Walzer prefers complex equality across distinct social spheres. (PDF pp.472-473)	Persons are situated selves whose good is discovered through shared practices and deeper commonality. (PDF pp.470-472)	Critiques liberal neutrality and the abstract or unencumbered self; is itself criticized for weak political mechanism. (PDF pp.469-473)

MECHANISM	Running the comparison on shared axes converts a description into an adjudication.
TRAP / LIMIT	Democratic socialism is just Marxism without elections -> It explicitly insists on freedom of thought, multi-party competition and opposition rights. (PDF pp.460-461)
ANSWER LINE	Perspective - Distribution rule - State - Property - Equality - Community - Critique

EXAMINER TRAP FIREWALL

TRAP	Rawls wants identical outcomes for all
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TRAP	Feminism only demands that women be treated exactly like men in every situation
REPAIR	Gauba also notes claims for maternity benefits and compensatory support rooted in actual disadvantage. (PDF pp.466-468)
TRAP	Communitarian criticism means justice should give way to blind conformity
REPAIR	The criticism is directed at the abstract self and ethical neutrality, not at the very idea of justice. (PDF pp.469-473)
MECHANISM	Each pair is a tested misreading followed by the exact repair the source supports.
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ANSWER LINE	Rawls wants identical outcomes for all. -> Rawls permits inequality after liberty and fair opportunity, provided it benefits the least advantaged. (PDF p.448)

OWNERSHIP BOUNDARIES AND CROSS-LINKS

THIS TOPIC OWNS

- Read Political-Theory/advanced/20_Diverse-Perspectives-on-Justice.md for deeper criticism, Walzer's complex equality and thinker-by-thinker reconstruction
- Conceptual prequel: Political-Theory/basic/03_Liberalism-and-Neoliberalism.md for liberal and libertarian background
- Socialist and anarchist background: Political-Theory/basic/04_Marxism-and-Neo-Marxism.md and Political-Theory/basic/05_Socialism-Fascism-Anarchism-and-Gandhism.md
- Gender and community background: Political-Theory/basic/06_Feminism-Sex-and-Gender.md and Political-Theory/basic/07_Nature-of-Politics-and-Communitarianism.md
- State-role boundary: Political-Theory/basic/10_State-Civil-Society-Nation-and-Internationalism.md
- Module frame and topic map: Political-Theory/00_Master-Framework.md and Political-Theory/README.md
- Boundary: this file stays conceptual and does not duplicate constitutional reservations law, welfare statutes or court doctrine
- Scope boundary: this canonical owner covers Gauba's eight chapter-framed perspectives. Capability and recognition are separately sourced extensions; multicultural, environmental/intergenerational, postcolonial and global justice remain external cross-routes unless independently sourced in their own owners

DELEGATED OR EXCLUDED

- Direct constitutional, scheme and case facts

- Gender and community background: Political-Theory/basic/00_Feminist-Sex-and-Gender.md and Political-Theory/basic/07_Nature-of-Politics-and-Communitarianism.md
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- 2019, 10 marks: "How far do you think John Rawls is continuing with Plato's concept of justice?" Primary owner: Philosophy Paper II - Social and Political Ideals
- 2021, 10 marks: "Discuss critically the distributive theory of justice as propounded by R. Nozick." Primary owner: Philosophy Paper II - Social and Political Ideals
- 2022, 15 marks: "Explain the difference between the notion of equity and equality with reference to Marxian philosophy." Primary owner: Philosophy Paper II - Social and Political Ideals
- 2023, 10 marks: "What is meant by justice as fairness? Explain Rawls' theory of justice." Primary owner: Philosophy Paper II - Social and Political Ideals

MECHANISM Syllabus boundary discipline prevents a conceptual answer from being marked down as off-topic.

TRAP / LIMIT Communitarian criticism means justice should give way to blind conformity -> The criticism is directed at the abstract self and ethical neutrality, not at the very idea of justice. (PDF pp.469-473)

ANSWER LINE Rawls: two principles - equal basic liberties; then fair opportunity plus the difference

9 REVISION CAPSULE AND ANSWER SPINE

- Rawls: two principles - equal basic liberties; then fair opportunity plus the difference principle in lexical order. Gauba presents the second principle's two parts as separate steps (PDF pp.447-450)
- Nozick: justice in holdings = acquisition + transfer + rectification under minimal state. (PDF pp.450-452)
- Marxist: injustice lies in exploitation and private ownership of major means of production; communist justice points to need-based distribution. (PDF pp.453-459)
- Democratic-socialist: welfare and social ownership must coexist with civil liberties and democratic competition. (PDF pp.459-461)
- Anarchist: justice seeks release from coercive authority and domination through voluntary association. (PDF pp.461-464)
- Feminist, subaltern and communitarian critiques widen justice beyond market shares to gendered power, structural subordination and embedded community meanings. (PDF pp.464-473)
- Walzer adds the important reminder that equality can mean keeping money from colonizing every other sphere of life. (PDF pp.472-473)
- One-line synthesis: Gauba's chapter moves from fair procedure, to valid title, to structural exploitation, structured subordination and finally to shared meanings of goods; recognition is a later analytical extension
- Best answer move: compare each theory on rule of distribution, role of state, treatment of property, idea of equality, view of community, and strongest criticism
- Verified PYQ (2023): What is justice as fairness? Explain Rawls's theory of justice
- PYQ trap: do not write only the difference principle; define original position and veil of ignorance, state the two principles and their priority, then add objections

MECHANISM The capsule is the last-minute recall rail; it should be reproducible in under two minutes.

ANSWER LINE Rawls, reconstructed for answer-writing (synthesis of PDF pp.447-450, not a direct quotation): P1: rational agents choose principles behind a veil of ignorance, unaware of their own place

10 GS MAINS QUESTION ROUTES CARRIED BY THIS TOPIC

10-mark route

Distinguish Rawls's difference principle from Nozick's entitlement theory. Answer in 150 words

10-mark route

Compare feminist and subaltern critiques of distributive justice. Answer in 150 words

15-mark route

Can justice be exhausted by redistribution? Discuss with Rawls, Fraser and Ambedkarian/subaltern implications. Answer in 250 words

10-mark route

Why is Walzer's complex equality not simple levelling? Answer in 150 words

15-mark route

Does Sen improve Rawls, or mainly change the metric of justice? Answer in 250 words

15-mark route

Evaluate whether democratic socialism is the strongest correction to both libertarianism and Marxist centralism. Answer in 250 words.

MECHANISM Directive fidelity, not content volume, decides the band a Mains answer lands in.

ANSWER LINE All Indian illustrations in this section are exam-use analytical bridges. They must not be cited with a Gauba PDF page number

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MECHANISM	The capsule is the last-minute recall rail; it should be reproducible in under two minutes.
ANSWER LINE	Rawls, reconstructed for answer-writing (synthesis of PDF pp.447-450, not a direct quotation): P1: rational agents choose principles behind a veil of ignorance, unaware of their own place

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GS MAINS QUESTION ROUTES CARRIED BY THIS TOPIC

10-mark route Distinguish Rawls's difference principle from Nozick's entitlement theory. Answer in 150 words	10-mark route Why is Walzer's complex equality not simple levelling? Answer in 150 words
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MECHANISM	Directive fidelity, not content volume, decides the band a Mains answer lands in.
ANSWER LINE	All Indian illustrations in this section are exam-use analytical bridges. They must not be cited with a Gauba PDF page number

QUALIFIED VERDICT Rawls, reconstructed for answer-writing (synthesis of PDF pp. 447-450, not a direct quotation): P1: rational agents choose principles behind a veil of ignorance, unaware of their own place Gauba begins with the liberal perspective and presents Rawls as the major attempt to reconcile liberty with equality and fraternity within a broader liberal frame.
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